

Action plan for 2025-2027 of Forte to follow up on the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA)

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About Forte

Forte – Swedish research council for health, working life and welfare is one of four research funding agencies in Sweden. On behalf of the government, Forte initiates and funds basic and needs-driven research within the research fields health, working life and welfare. Forte's mission is to develop knowledge in areas that are crucial to people's daily lives and that at the same time represent key elements of Swedish welfare. To meet society's needs for knowledge, the research Forte funds must fill important knowledge gaps. Forte therefore needs to focus continuously on ensuring that the research we initiate and fund is highly relevant so that it contributes to good health, sustainable working life and a high level of welfare for everyone in Swedish society. To this end, Forte uses various instruments such as project grants, grants for career support and grants for collaboration support, among others. Forte also works actively to stimulate international research collaborations within the Nordic region, the EU and worldwide. Forte's vision is that the research we fund today forms the scientific basis for the more equitable and socially sustainable society of tomorrow. Forte's goals are to initiate and fund research of high scientific quality that makes a difference for society and people's lives and to be actively involved in national and global knowledge building.

Forte's accession to CoARA

Forte signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) and joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment's (CoARA) on December 18, 2022. The agreement sets a shared direction for changes in assessment practices for research with the overarching goal to maximise the quality and impact of research, which aligns with the priorities of Forte to recognise a diversity of outputs, practices and activities to maximise the quality and impact of research. A central component is to use qualitative assessment of research, a practice which Forte is firmly dedicated to.

Starting point

To fulfil our goal to fund research of high scientific quality that makes a difference for society and people's lives, Forte performs rigorous assessments of the applications submitted to our calls for proposals. The assessments are generally made by reviewers from the scientific community as well as community representatives, the latter to ensure that the research is relevant to the wider community. The reviewers are part of a review panel that collectively makes decisions. Commonly, Forte does not use external reviewers to provide written assessments of the applications as support for the review panel.

Applications for funding are generally assessed against three main sets of criteria and a set of requirements. The focus of the assessment is on the proposals of the research as described in the application. The requirements include relevance to Fortes fields of research, sex and gender perspectives and ethical considerations. The three sets of criteria include scientific quality, societal relevance and utilisation, and feasibility. Only part of the feasibility criteria concerns the track record of the applicants, where quantitative indicators could play a meaningful role. However, Forte does not include any quantitative indicators in our application forms, and the reviewers are expected not to base their assessment on any information outside of the application. Furthermore, Forte has restricted the number of items the applicants may list in their CVs and lists of publications for each application.

As noted, one of three sets of assessment criteria generally used at Forte is societal relevance and utilisation, where we assess the relevance for and communication and cooperation with stakeholders. This has been implemented to strengthen the impact of the research that is funded and to ensure that we fulfil our goal of making a difference for society and people's lives.

An important aspect of the assessment process at Forte is that it relies heavily on the discussion among the reviewers in our review panels. Here, it is the arguments that are put forward in the discussion that forms the basis of the decisions that are made, rather than the accumulation of individual assessments. Therefore, Forte generally does not use of grades in the assessment of research proposals. Instead, we promote a consensus-based decision-making process where the applications are prioritised that most closely meet the purpose of the call and fulfil its assessment criteria.

In line with our mission from the government, Forte is dedicated to continuously develop our instruments, tools and processes to enable better goal-attainment and to increase the efficiency of our work as well as the quality in our processes and of our performances. To this end, we have resources dedicated in-house and we also work in cooperation with several of the other national research funding agencies with whom we share a system for application for grants and assessment of applications. Starting in 2024, Forte has also launched a three-year project with the aim of developing several defined aspects of our research funding process, including a new website that can better support our applicants, reviewers, funded researchers and research users. The project targets issues that have been identified as important to strengthen the quality of our research funding process.

Forte has also during 2023 and 2024 carried out an observational study of our review panels, focussing on procedural challenges to our effort of ensuring that those seeking funding are assessed in a transparent, legally secure and equal manner. The study has had a particular focus on a gender equal distribution of research funding, but it has also identified other forms of bias in the assessment process. The purpose of the study has been to better align our practical work with our policies established to ensure fair assessment.

Action plan

Signing the ARRA and joining CoARA has not implied a major shift in the priorities of Forte. Forte has already been committed to qualitative research assessment that recognises a diversity of contributions to research, as well as the wider community.

A current challenge for Forte is to be able to assess the increasing number of applications to our calls in an equitable way that guarantees fair process. A priority is therefore to further develop our assessment tools and processes to meet this challenge. Another priority is to ensure that the mission we have been given and the policies we have adopted are acted upon accordingly. Here, we will benefit from the observational study recently performed, as well as further work aimed at assisting reviewers and in-house staff in the assessment process.

As always, we discuss potential changes and developments with our reviewers, as well as our board that are constituted of active researchers and community representatives. We are also engaged in national and international networks of research funders and research performing organisations that contribute to knowledge exchange regarding the way Forte is working to advance the way we assess research.

CoARA commitments

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research

In the applications, Forte requires the applicants to choose the most relevant experiences to include that can demonstrate their ability to perform the proposed research. This includes educational attainments, occupations, publications and other merits. However, continuous work is required to further investigate whether all types of experiences, research results and research outputs that may be of relevance can be included in the applications. Furthermore, it is important that a diversity of contributions is also recognised in the assessment. To what extent this is the case is a matter for further evaluation.

In the assessment of research proposals, Forte includes not only the importance of the research for the academic community, but also its potential societal relevance and impact. The balance in valuing these different outcomes varies between different calls and funding instruments, depending on their specific purpose. Forte is continuously working to ensure that we can provide funding instruments and use assessment criteria that satisfies various knowledge needs.

2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

Forte is firmly dedicated to qualitative assessment and uses no quantitative indicators in our application forms. We also inform our reviewers that the assessment is to be made only of the information in the applications. The recently performed observational study will aid us in identifying and ameliorating potential problems in abiding by our policies and procedures. This is a current priority.

3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index
 Forte does not include this type of quantitative measures in our assessment of research applications. With the recent observational study, we have examined the extent to which it is a problem that individual reviewers mention this type of information. Following up on the study, Forte intends to find more and better ways to support our review panels in rejecting irrelevant information, such as this.
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment
 The ranking of research organisations is not of relevance for the assessments made at Forte, but to the extent that reviewers mention this type of information, the above-mentioned observational study is part of our efforts to counter such arguments.
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to
 Forte is continuously working to develop our research funding processes and tools in accordance with our needs as they develop. As part of this work, we have initiated a three-year project, to give extra boost to much needed development of our research funding tools and processes.
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes
 In recent years, Forte has undertaken an effort to develop our assessment criteria. This has mainly had two results: a clarification of what is meant by each criterion and a differentiation between funding programmes so that the criteria match the purpose of each programme. A follow-up will be made of the implementation of the criteria.
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
 It is a continuous effort to develop our processes and material for guiding our reviewers, which Forte will keep up. We also plan to better describe our process to applicants and others not involved in the evaluation process. A better visualization of the process of each call for proposals will be implemented with our new website in 2025.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition
 Forte is engaged in CoARA, its working group “Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals”, its Swedish chapter, Science Europe (the working groups “Research Culture” and “Open Science”) and continuously meet with other national funders to discuss these and related challenges. However, due to limited resources, we must prioritise our participation in these types of fora.
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments

Forte will communicate with applicants, reviewers and the academic community at large about relevant changes made to our assessment processes through relevant changes such as our website, social media and direct communication. The intention is also that progress made will be included in updated versions of the CoARA Action plan.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

Forte is positive to the evaluation of our work to guarantee best practice, as well as to share the results of such evaluation openly. As an example of this, we published a report in November 2024 where we analysed whether the research proposed in applications to Forte focussed on description, explanation or problem-solving. As another example, we will publish the report from the recent observational study during 2025. However, we have little capacity to perform systematic evaluation of our work and will have to prioritise such efforts.